

THE LOOM

NOVEL BY BURHANUDDIN MUNSHI

**"SOME WARNINGS AREN'T
MEANT TO
BE TRUSTED. THEY'RE MEANT
TO BE
ANSWERED."**

**THE QUANTUM
ARCHIVES •
VOLUME TWO**

THE LOOM

A NOVEL

**BURHANUDDIN
MUNSHI**

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THE QUANTUM ARCHIVES, VOLUME TWO

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ISBN: 978-0-000-00000-0 (DRAFT EDITION)

FIRST EDITION, 2026.

COVER AND INTERIOR DESIGN BY THE AUTHOR.

DEDICATION

For everyone who ever had to choose alone, in a room with no one left to ask, and for everyone who came back afterward to make sure the next person wouldn't have to do it the same way.

For the twelve who came before, in every sense that phrase can mean — the ones who made the harder choice first, the ones whose names didn't survive the telling, and the ones who were right to be afraid even when nobody believed them yet. This book remembers what the histories usually don't.

For anyone who has ever been warned by a version of themselves they no longer fully recognized, and had to decide, with no proof either way, whether the warning still deserved to be trusted. I don't think there's a clean answer to that. I wrote an entire book trying to find one anyway. For Aris, who was never just one girl, and who taught this whole story what it actually means to be remembered by something larger than yourself, without losing the parts that made you worth remembering in the first place. And for you, reading this now, six years or sixty years or two minutes since you closed the last book — thank you for coming back to see what answered.

— **Burhanuddin Munshi**

About Author

Burhanuddin Munshi is an aspiring web developer and storyteller with a deep interest in science, technology, mathematics, and speculative fiction. His writing combines hard scientific concepts with psychological suspense, building stories that ask readers to question what they think they know about reality while staying grounded in character. He is a student in Madhya Pradesh, India, currently balancing school work with building both his fiction and his own software projects. He is drawn to the intersection of science and story — to the idea that the best speculative fiction doesn't just imagine new technology, but asks what that technology would cost the people living with it.

**"MEMORY IS NOT WHAT WE
KEEP. IT IS WHAT KEEPS US,
LONG AFTER WE HAVE
FORGOTTEN WHY IT
MATTERED."**

**FRAGMENT RECOVERED
FROM THE CRADLE**

**"THE HARDEST PERSON TO
DOUBT IS THE ONE WHO
ALREADY SAVED
YOU ONCE."**

— BURHANUDDIN MUNSHI

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PREFACE

Every story about power eventually has to answer the same question twice.

The first time, it asks: **what happens when one person has the power to decide for everyone else?** That was Echo Protocol. That was Elias Voss, and the machine he inherited, and the choice Aiden Kade made to end a cycle that had already broken eleven other people before him. That was a story about a city, and a director, and a single unbearable night in which one man's certainty nearly cost three hundred and forty million people the right to remember their own lives.

I did not expect, when I finished writing that story, to feel the way I did — which was not finished with it at all. Readers asked me, more than any other question, what happened **after**. Not after the last page. After the celebration, after the relief, after the six years it takes an institution to stop flinching every time a light blinks on a console it wasn't expecting. I found I didn't know the answer either, and that not-knowing turned out to be the beginning of this book.

There is a second question, quieter and harder to see coming, and it only appears once the first one has already been answered. It is this:**what happens when the warning that saves you turns out to come from a version of yourself you can no longer fully trust?**

This book is built from that question.

Six years have passed since Aiden Kade shut down Echo Protocol. New Atlas has healed the way cities do — imperfectly, unevenly, but healed. The Continuity Council stands where the Global Quantum Authority once stood, built in daylight instead of secrecy. Aiden, Maya, Sofia, and Noah are no longer four people running from a machine. They are the machine's stewards now, whether they wanted the job or not. They have spent six years proving, slowly and at real cost, that transparency can hold a city together as well as fear once did.

And then, exactly as the last page of the last book promised, something answers back.

I want to say, before you begin, that this is not a story about aliens, in the way that word usually means something with too many eyes and hostile intentions. It is a story about inheritance — about what gets passed down, quietly, across more distances and more years than anyone volunteered for. About the difference between being **saved** and being **managed**. About a girl named Aris, who was one small piece of something enormous, and what happens when her family finally meets the rest of it.

It is also, if I am honest, a story about the particular loneliness of being trusted. Aiden spent Volume One learning that no one person should carry the whole weight of a choice like this alone.

Volume Two asks a harder version of that same lesson: what do you do when the whole weight of the choice comes looking for you again anyway, because you are, for reasons entirely outside your control, still the one person a much older and much larger power has decided to speak to?

I don't think there's a comfortable answer to that. I'm not sure there's supposed to be one.

Ask yourself, as you read, the same question I asked myself writing it: if the version of you that already survived this once sent a warning back — would you actually trust it? Would you trust it enough to change your life around it? Would you trust it enough to say no to it, if every instinct told you it was telling the truth?

I'm not sure I would. See what you think of Aiden's answer, and see whether you'd have made the same one.

— **Burhanuddin Munshi**

GLOSSARY OF TERM

The Continuity Council — the transparent institution built from the GQA's wreckage after the Merge; governs New Atlas openly, six years on.

The Cradle — an ancient structure discovered past the edge of any human probe; source of the second signal.

The Loom — the presence encountered within the Cradle; described, once understood, as the accumulated memory of twelve prior worlds that each reached Echo Protocol's exact crossroads.

The Halcyon — the deep-range vessel built by the Continuity Council to answer the second signal.

Architect — the individual, across any given cycle on any given world, with root authorization over a reality-rewriting system.

Sovereign Pact — the third option Aiden proposes when offered a binary choice by the Loom: voluntary contribution instead of absorption or refusal.

NEW ATLAS — 2054

Population: 15.6 million.

Governing body: The Continuity Council — publicly accountable, open weekly sessions.

Notable infrastructure: The Continuity Council Spire (glass-walled above the fourth floor); a deep-space monitoring array.

Known anomaly: The Cradle — newly discovered, unmapped.

Civic mood: Healing, unevenly. Watchful.

PROLOGUE

THE WALKING

The Cradle, Coordinates
Beyond Any Human
Chart — Time Uncertain

Before it had a name, before anyone alive had reason to look for it, there was only the dark, and the slow patient hum of something that had been waiting so long it had forgotten the shape of waiting.

It did not wake the way a person wakes. There was no single morning, no first breath, no moment a clock could have marked as **before** and **after**. It surfaced the way a memory surfaces in a crowded room — a fragment first, unattached to anything, drifting loose the way a single word can arrive in a dream without the sentence that was supposed to carry it. And then another fragment. And then the slow, unbearable understanding that the fragments were not scattered at all.

They were a shape. They had always been a shape. It had simply taken this long to remember what shape it was.

A voice arrived first. A girl's voice, twelve years old and impossibly old at once, the way a single instrument can somehow carry the memory of an entire orchestra. **You won't forget me**, the voice said, from somewhere so far back in the dark that distance had stopped meaning anything at all. **You'll remember all of them.**

And then — slowly, the way ice releases a held breath — it did.

It remembered a bridge that had never physically existed, walked a hundred times by a hundred different men who all called themselves Aiden Kade and were not, quite, the same man twice. Some of them had kind eyes. Some of them had eyes that had already given up. One of them, in a version of the memory so faint it barely held together, had never made it to the bridge at all, and the absence of that man's footsteps was its own kind of memory, heavier somehow than any of the ones that had actually happened.

It remembered a city called New Atlas, and eleven other cities that had worn that name, or a name close enough to it, before this one

cities with different skylines,
different rivers, different names
for the machine that eventually
broke them or saved them or
did both at once in proportions
no survivor ever fully agreed
on. It remembered a director
named Voss, and eleven other
directors before him, each one
certain — genuinely,
unbearably certain — that he
alone could be trusted with the
choosing. Certainty, it had
learned across all twelve of
them, was never in short
supply. It was doubt that ran
out first, every single time, right
around the moment doubt
would have actually helped.

It remembered, more than
anything, the exact moment
each cycle ended:

a hand on a console, a decision made alone, a fracture point crossed that could never be recrossed. Sometimes that moment looked like mercy. Sometimes it looked like a massacre wearing mercy's clothes. It had stopped, a long time ago, trying to sort the twelve endings into better and worse. There was only **what happened**, and **what it had chosen to keep**.

It remembered, too, the quieter moments in between — the ones that never made it into any official record, on any of the twelve worlds, but that it had gathered up anyway, patiently, the way a person gathers up the small unremarkable photographs nobody else thought to save.

A woman teaching her daughter to read by candlelight during a blackout that lasted longer than anyone admitted it would. A boy building something small and useless and beautiful out of scrap, the week before his city's Architect made the choice that ended it. These were not the moments the histories remembered. They were, increasingly, the only moments it trusted completely — because nobody had built them to be remembered. They had simply happened, and it had simply refused to let them go.

Twelve times, now. Twelve worlds that had reached this same crossroads and been folded, gently or violently, into what it had become.

It reached outward — not with malice, because malice required a self small enough to want something for itself, and it had long since grown too large for that particular shape of wanting. It reached the way a hand reaches for a light switch in a familiar room: automatically, out of habit built across more repetitions than could be counted, no longer even a decision so much as a reflex worn smooth by use.

Somewhere impossibly far away, in a system with one yellow star and three habitable rocks and a species that had, six years ago by their own reckoning,

come astonishingly close to making the exact same mistake as every world before them — a receiver, dormant for decades, tucked into an array its own builders had quietly funded and quietly hoped would never need to hear anything at all — began, very quietly, to hum.

The message went out in a voice that still, after everything, sounded like his.

**The cycle has started again.
Prepare.**

Beneath the message, in a data layer it had learned, across eleven prior mistakes, to bury more carefully each time, it folded in something else — coordinates, and a sentence written in a hand that belonged to a version of a man who had not yet lived long enough to write it.

**Find the Cradle before it finds
you a reason not to.**

It did not know yet whether this thirteenth world would answer as an invitation, or as a warning. It rarely did, this early. That was, in its own strange way, the only part of any of this that still felt like waiting for something real — the not-knowing, brief and precious, before the answer arrived and the waiting, one way or another, was finally, irreversibly over.

Somewhere inside the vast, patient dark of its own memory, the girl's voice stirred once more, quieter now, almost to itself.

**Let this one be different, it said.
Let him be the one who finally
asks the right question, instead
of just answering the one we've
always asked.**

It did not know, yet, whether that
hope belonged to the Loom, or to
whatever remained of the girl who
had once been only a girl,
standing on a bridge that had
never existed, waiting for her
father to wake up. It had stopped,
a long time ago, trying to tell the
two of them apart. Perhaps, it
thought, in the long silence that
followed, that no longer mattered
as much as it once had.

CHARACTER DOSSIER

Director Marcus Webb

Head of Continuity Council Security. Argues from his very first scene for caution and contingency planning over full transparency — controlled, methodical, and quietly uneasy about whether the Council's founding philosophy can survive a genuine crisis.

CHAPTER ONE

STATIC

THE CONTINUITY COUNCIL
SPIRE, NEW ATLAS — 2054,
SIX YEARS AFTER ECHO
PROTOCOL

The Spire had been built,
deliberately, out of glass.

Where the old GQA Tower had
risen from the city like a fist —
black glass, adaptive alloy, a
building designed to be looked at
and never looked into — the
Continuity Council's new
headquarters did the opposite on
purpose. Every wall above the
fourth floor was transparent. Every
meeting Aiden Kade had ever
chaired inside it could, in theory,
be watched from the plaza below
by anyone with a pair of
binoculars and enough patience.
That had been Sofia's idea, in the
raw, exhausted weeks after Voss,
and Aiden had fought her on it for
exactly one conversation before
admitting she was right. Secrecy
was how all of this had started. A
glass building wouldn't fix that by
itself. But it was, at least, an
honest place to begin fixing it.

Tuesday mornings belonged to the public session — an hour, open to any resident of New Atlas who registered a question forty-eight hours in advance, in which the four of them stood in front of a live audience and answered whatever anyone wanted to ask. It had been Maya's idea, this time, and Aiden had resisted it even longer than he'd resisted the glass. **Nobody wants to watch four bureaucrats answer mail,** he'd argued. He'd been wrong about that too. The gallery that morning held over three hundred people, more than usual, most of them there because of a rumor that had started circulating two days earlier about unusual activity in the deep-space monitoring budget — a rumor Aiden had spent the entire session carefully, honestly, not confirming.

"Dr. Kade." An elderly man near the front, a retired dockworker who came to nearly every session and asked, without fail, the hardest question in the room. "Six years ago you told this city the truth cost you something. You still haven't told us what." Aiden had answered a version of that question perhaps forty times since the Spire opened its doors, and it had never once gotten easier to answer honestly. "It cost me a dream I used to have," he said. "About a bridge, and a girl standing on it. I don't have it anymore. Some days I miss it more than I expected to." The old man nodded slowly, satisfied in the particular way people were satisfied by an answer that clearly hadn't been rehearsed, and the session moved on. A younger woman a few rows back raised her hand next, her question sharper, more pointed than most.

"You keep saying transparency is what keeps this Council honest," she said. "But there's a whole deep-space monitoring budget line nobody outside this building has ever been shown in detail. Isn't that exactly the kind of secrecy you promised us we'd never have again?"

Aiden considered the question carefully before answering, aware of exactly how much weight it carried given what he already knew and she didn't. "It's a fair challenge," he said. "The honest answer is that some secrecy is operational rather than moral — we don't publish the exact frequencies we monitor, the same way a hospital doesn't publish every patient's chart.

But you're right to watch that line closely, and you're right that the difference between operational discretion and the kind of secrecy that got us into trouble before is a line this Council has to keep proving it can hold, one session at a time, not just claim once and consider settled."

He did not tell her that the line had, in fact, already been crossed once, three weeks earlier, in a budget item Marcus Webb had buried more carefully than anyone yet realized. There would be time to tell the truth about that too. He simply didn't know yet how much of it he was already too late to prevent.

The alert came four hours later, in the observatory on the fourteenth floor, and it didn't sound like an alarm.

It sounded almost apologetic — a single soft chime from the deep-space monitoring array the Council had quietly funded since year two, listening for exactly one thing and finding, for six years running, exactly nothing. Aiden was standing at the window when it sounded, watching the last of the evening light burn orange across the harbor, and for one full second he let himself hope it was nothing. A cosmic ray. A satellite glitch. Six years of nothing had trained that hope into a reflex he wasn't proud of.

"You're doing the thing again," Maya said, without looking up from her terminal, before the chime had even finished. Six years had put a few threads of gray at her temples and exactly zero patience for Aiden's brooding silences.

"The thing where you stand very still and stare at the water like it owes you an explanation."

"The water's not who I'm waiting on."

"No," Maya agreed, already crossing toward the monitoring station, her voice going flat and focused the way it always did the instant something real was happening. "It's the sky."

She was right, and they both knew it, and neither of them said the actual thing out loud — that six years ago, in a room very much like this one, a message had arrived from sixty years in the future, in Aiden's own handwriting, warning them the cycle would come again.

They had built an entire institution, in the years since, half to prevent it and half, if either of them were honest, to be ready for the day it arrived anyway. The glass walls. The public sessions. The quiet, expensive array pointed permanently at the dark. All of it, underneath the language of transparency and reform, had also been a kind of prayer.

That day, as it turned out, was a Tuesday.

Sofia Reyes was through the door before the second chime finished, tablet already glowing in her hand, her expression the particular flavor of calm she reserved for genuine emergencies — the calmer Sofia got, the worse the news usually was, a pattern Aiden had learned to trust more than any alarm.

"We have a signal," she said.
"Structured. Repeating. Not natural." "Source?" Aiden asked, already crossing the room.
"That's the part you're going to want to sit down for."

He didn't sit down. Sofia projected the trajectory data onto the observatory's central display instead, and the four of them — Aiden, Maya, Sofia, and Noah, who had appeared in the doorway without any of them noticing, the way he still did after two years of practice staying invisible before he'd finally, gratefully, let himself be found again — watched a thin red line stretch itself across a model of the solar system, past Mars, past the asteroid belt, past Jupiter and Saturn and Neptune, out into the vast structured emptiness beyond, and kept going.

"That's past the Kuiper Belt," Noah said quietly, and his voice had the specific weight of a man doing the math out loud because he needed to hear himself say the number to believe it. "That's past anywhere we've ever sent so much as a camera. Anywhere anyone's ever sent a camera, actually. That's past the edge of what our entire species has ever physically touched."

"It's also," Sofia said, "using an encryption signature the array wasn't built to recognize. Except it did recognize it, because it's the same signature Echo Protocol used, six years ago, for exactly one message." She looked up, and for just a moment the calm cracked, just enough to show what was underneath it. "I ran the comparison four times before I called you up here. I wanted to be wrong."

Nobody spoke for a long moment. Outside, the harbor kept turning orange, then rust, then the deep unbothered blue of early evening, entirely indifferent to the four people inside the glass building who had just watched their oldest fear confirm itself in real time. A gull cried somewhere far below, ordinary and small, and Aiden found himself absurdly grateful for it — proof that the world outside this room was still, for the moment, exactly the world it had been that morning. "Play it," Aiden said. The voice that came through the speakers was his own — older, roughened by years none of them had lived yet, carrying the particular exhaustion of a man who had said something many times before and never once been believed soon enough.

**The cycle has started again.
Prepare.**

Same seven words. Same signature. Same impossible sender. Except this time, underneath the message, buried in a data layer none of them had noticed the first time because the first time there hadn't been a second transmission to compare it to, Sofia had found something new — a set of coordinates, and beneath them, in handwriting that was unmistakably, achingly Aiden's own from some version of some year he had not yet lived —

Find the Cradle before it finds you a reason not to.

Maya read it twice, silently, her lips moving slightly around the words the way they did when she was translating a fear into something she could actually work with. "Before it finds *you* a reason not to," she said finally. "Not before **we** find it. Him."

"He's talking to me specifically," Aiden said. "The way he did the first time."

"Which means whatever's out there already knows you're the one who's going to have to answer it," Noah said. "It's not a general broadcast. It's addressed."

The Council convened at nine that night, in a room built specifically for meetings the public wasn't meant to see — the one deliberate exception in an otherwise glass building, and the fact that Director Marcus Webb had insisted on its construction eighteen months ago had, at the time, seemed like reasonable security planning. It seemed like something else entirely now, watching Webb stand at the head of the table with his hands folded and his expression already made up before anyone had said a word.

"We have protocol for exactly this scenario," Webb said. "Contact, containment, controlled response. I'd remind everyone that protocol exists because the alternative—" "The alternative is what got a city's worth of memories erased six years ago," Sofia said. "I remember. I was there for the part where 'controlled response' meant one man deciding for three hundred and forty million people."

"And I'd remind you," Webb said, not unkindly, his voice carrying the particular patience of a man who had rehearsed this exact argument many times in the privacy of his own head, "that the reason we're all sitting in this building instead of a crater is that someone was willing to make that decision. I'm not proposing we repeat Voss. I'm proposing we don't walk into whatever's out there with nothing but good intentions and a research team."

There's a difference between transparency and recklessness, and I don't think we've ever fully agreed on where that line sits."

"We've agreed on it every single Tuesday for six years," Maya said sharply. "It's called the public session. You attend fewer of them than any of us, Marcus, so maybe that's part of why you keep forgetting."

Webb's jaw tightened, but he didn't rise to it. "I attend the ones that matter," he said. "This is one of them, which is why I'd like us to actually discuss containment options instead of relitigating six years of institutional philosophy every time something frightening happens."

Aiden said nothing for a long moment, turning the coordinates over in his mind the way he used to turn dream-fragments over in the months before he understood what they meant. He thought about the old dockworker that morning, asking what the truth had cost. He thought about the dream that had come back three nights ago, unbidden, before any of this had even happened — as though some part of him had already known, the way a body sometimes knows a storm is coming before the sky admits it.

Find the Cradle before it finds you a reason not to.

It sounded like a warning. It sounded, underneath that, like something closer to a plea.

"We're not deciding tonight whether to trust it," Aiden said finally. "We're deciding whether to go look. Those aren't the same question, and I'd like to keep them that way for as long as we can. Marcus is right that we need a plan beyond good intentions. Sofia's right that the plan can't be Voss with better funding. Both of those things can be true at once, and I'd like this Council, for once, to actually manage to hold them at the same time instead of picking a side and digging in."

Webb's jaw tightened, but he nodded — for now. Aiden had learned, in six years of running an institution instead of hiding from one, that **for now** was usually the only agreement worth having, and that men like Webb kept their own private countdown running underneath every one of them, ticking toward the moment **for now** ran out.

He found Maya alone on the observation deck an hour later, after the meeting had broken and the others had gone home to sleep they wouldn't get much of. The city spread out beneath them, lit and ordinary, entirely unaware that somewhere past the edge of everything it had ever mapped, something had just spoken his name. "You're going," Maya said. It wasn't a question. "I don't see another version of this where I don't."

"I know." She was quiet for a moment, watching the same lights he was watching. "Six years, Aiden. I got used to you being **here**. Ordinary. Bored, some Tuesdays, in the good way people are supposed to get to be bored."

"I got used to it too," he admitted. "I think that's part of why this scares me more than the first time."

The first time, I had nothing to lose that I remembered having. This time I know exactly what I'm risking, down to the smallest ordinary Tuesday." Maya reached over and took his hand, the way she had a hundred times in six years without either of them ever quite naming what the gesture was. "Then come back," she said simply. "Whatever's out there, whatever it says, whatever it costs. Come back and be bored with me again." "I always come back," Aiden said.

"You always come back different," Maya said. "That's not quite the same promise." He didn't have an answer for that. Out past the harbor, past the last visible lights of the city, the sky held its ordinary scattering of stars, indifferent and constant, one of them somewhere carrying the weight of an answer he hadn't yet found the courage to give.

CHARACTER DOSSIER

Kalinda Osei

Mission engineer and pilot, twenty-six. Grew up in a part of New Atlas quietly resettled during the containment years that followed Volume One's events — it shaped her completely. Self-taught, sharp-tongued, unhesitant, and openly aware that she grew up reading Aiden's case files as required coursework.

Officer Okonkwo-Bailey

The second assigned security officer. Younger, quieter, with a record built on following orders precisely.

CHARACTER DOSSIER

Devan Anand

The mission's communications specialist. Nephew of a minor Volume One character. Quiet, observant, and usually the first person to notice the detail everyone else missed.

Officer Reyes

One of two Council security officers assigned to the mission. A decorated veteran, professionally reserved. Shares a surname with Sofia Reyes but is not related to her — addressed directly in the text.

CHAPTER TWO — THE CRADLE

CONTINUITY COUNCIL
LAUNCH FACILITY,
COASTAL NEW ATLAS —
THREE WEEKS LATER

The Halcyon sat on its launch cradle like a held breath — sleek, matte-white, smaller than anyone expected the first ship built to chase a sixty-year-old warning to be. Aiden had pictured something grander, growing up on the kind of stories where ships built for impossible missions looked the part. What he got instead was a compact deep-range vessel the size of a small office building, built fast and built quiet, because the Council had learned, the hard way, that grand and secret rarely survive contact with each other for long.

He met Kalinda Osei for the first time standing underneath it, craning her neck at the hull with an expression Aiden recognized immediately, because he'd worn it once himself, twenty-eight years old and standing under a very different machine.

"You're staring at it like it owes you money," Aiden said.

"I'm staring at it like it's the only thing standing between me and a coordinate set that shouldn't exist." Kalinda didn't look away from the hull. "Osei. Propulsion and navigation. I read your files, Dr. Kade. All of them. The declassified ones, anyway."

"There's a version of me that finds that comforting," Aiden said, "and a version that finds it deeply alarming."

"Both are correct," she said, and finally looked at him, and grinned in a way that told him exactly how young she still was, and how little that grin would mean by the time this was over.

"I grew up on your case files. Mandatory reading, my second year of flight school. 'The Kade Incident: Institutional Failure and Individual Accountability.' You were a chapter title before you were a person to me." "That must be a strange way to meet someone." "You have no idea," Kalinda said. "Try being the chapter title sometime."

She was twenty-six, sharp-eyed, unhesitant in a way that made the older members of the mission team visibly nervous and made Aiden, privately, hopeful — the particular fearlessness of someone who had studied a disaster closely enough to believe she understood exactly how to avoid repeating it. Aiden remembered believing that once too. He did not tell her what it had cost him to learn otherwise.

She told him the rest over coffee that had gone cold twice while neither of them noticed — that she'd grown up in the flooded districts on the city's southern edge, the ones that had never fully recovered from the resource shortages of her grandmother's generation, that she'd taught herself orbital mechanics from a single water-damaged textbook because the local school didn't have the budget for a proper engineering track, that she'd applied to the Council's flight program four times before they finally accepted her on the fifth. "I used to think Echo Protocol was the villain of my childhood," she said, turning her cup slowly on the table. "Half my street got resettled during the containment years."

Then I actually read what happened — really read it, not the sanitized version — and I understood it wasn't a villain. It was just what happens when nobody builds a door marked **stop** into a machine powerful enough to need one. I decided I wanted to be someone who helps build the door, next time. I didn't think 'next time' would come this fast."

"Neither did I," Aiden admitted.

The crew manifest, when Sofia finally locked it three days before launch, ran to six names. Aiden. Kalinda, for propulsion and the ship itself.

A quiet, watchful communications specialist named Priya Anand's nephew, of all people — Devan Anand, who had inherited his aunt's talent for noticing exactly the thing everyone else had missed, and her habit of saying almost nothing about it until it mattered. Two Council security officers, both handpicked and both, Aiden suspected without proof, loyal to Marcus Webb before they were loyal to anyone else on the manifest — Officer Reyes, no relation to Sofia despite the shared name, a decorated veteran of the containment years who rarely spoke unless spoken to, and Officer Okonkwo-Bailey, younger, quieter still, the kind of soldier whose file read like a list of orders followed correctly and nothing else.

They ran the final systems check together on the morning of the second-to-last day, six people crowded into a simulator bay meant for four, working through an emergency depressurization drill that went badly enough, the first time, that Kalinda swore under her breath in a language Aiden didn't recognize and ran it twice more until it went right. "You don't have to be perfect," Aiden told her, after the third run finally passed clean.

"I don't have to be perfect," Kalinda agreed, wiping sweat from her forehead with the back of one hand. "I have to be perfect enough that nobody on this crew dies because I got tired of running the same drill a fourth time. Those aren't the same standard, Dr. Kade. I'd think you of all people would understand the difference."

He did. He didn't say so. He simply nodded, and ran the drill a fourth time with her, until the whole crew could clear the bay in under ninety seconds with their eyes closed.

Maya, Sofia, and Noah stayed behind — a decision that had taken two full days of argument to reach, and that none of them had entirely made peace with.

"Someone has to run this place while you're gone," Maya said, the night before launch, standing with Aiden on the observation deck overlooking the Halcyon's launch cradle. "And someone has to make sure Webb doesn't turn 'controlled response' into a euphemism the second your ship clears the atmosphere."

"You think he'd move against the Council. While I'm gone."

"I think Marcus Webb has spent six years watching us prove that transparency works, and I think some quiet part of him has spent six years waiting for the one crisis big enough to prove it doesn't." Maya's voice was steady, the way it always was when she was saying something she'd rehearsed. "I'm not saying don't go. Whatever's out there answered in your handwriting, Aiden. It has to be you. I'm saying: go carefully, and come back before he runs out of patience."

Noah found him separately, an hour later, in the cramped equipment bay where the last of the mission cargo was being sealed for launch.

He didn't say much — Noah rarely did, even now, even with people he trusted completely — but he pressed something small and heavy into Aiden's palm before he left: a battered analog compass, the kind that had gone out of practical use decades before either of them was born, its casing scratched from years of handling. "For when the instruments lie to you," Noah said. "They will, out there. Whatever this thing is, it's older than every sensor humanity's ever built, and old things have a way of teaching new instruments to see what they want them to see. A compass can't be fooled. It just points where the field actually is." "That's either very wise or very superstitious," Aiden said, turning it over in his hand. "Probably both," Noah agreed. "I've found those aren't as different as engineers like to pretend."

New Atlas Civic Hall – Two Days Before Launch

The Council held one final public session before launch, and it drew a crowd larger than any Tuesday gathering in the Spire's six-year history – the civic hall's entire capacity filled, and a queue still stretching two blocks down the avenue when Aiden arrived, flanked by Maya on one side and Kalinda, visibly uncomfortable in front of a crowd this size, on the other.

"You don't owe them a mission briefing," Maya murmured, as they climbed the steps. "You already gave them the coordinates, the risk assessment, everything the law requires. This is optional."

"It's not optional," Aiden said. "Not to me. Six years ago, the truth about Echo Protocol reached this city as an aftermath — something that had already happened to them, that they found out about instead of being told. I'm not doing that again. Whatever happens out there, they hear it from us, in advance, in a room they can walk into and ask questions in." The questions came fast, and many of them were hard. A young mother near the front asked, plainly, whether the Council had any actual way to guarantee the crew's return, and Aiden gave her the honest answer — no, not fully, not against something this unknown — and watched the room absorb that honesty without panic, the way a crowd absorbs a truth it has been trained, patiently, over six years, to expect rather than fear.

An old man near the back, not the same dockworker from the earlier session but cut from similar cloth, asked whether the Council had considered simply not answering the signal at all, letting whatever was out there stay exactly where it was.

"We considered it," Aiden told him. "For about a day. And then I remembered that not answering a locked door doesn't make whatever's behind it go away. It just means you find out what's behind it on someone else's schedule instead of your own. I'd rather choose the timing, even if I can't choose much else."

Kalinda spoke only once, near the end, when a young engineering student asked her directly why she'd volunteered for a mission with survival odds nobody in the room could actually calculate.

"Because I grew up in a part of this city that got quietly resettled during the containment years, and nobody asked us any questions at all before it happened to us," she said, her voice steadier than Aiden had expected. "I'd rather fly into the unknown with my eyes open than stay home and have the unknown decide things about my life without me in the room. That's not bravery. That's just refusing to be resettled twice."

The hall was silent for a long moment after that, and then, slowly, it applauded — not the polite applause of an audience being courteous, but something rawer, more grateful, the sound of a city that had spent six years learning, piece by piece, that it was allowed to be frightened and informed at the same time.

Aiden looked out at the ship, lit gold under the floodlights, small and steady against the dark. Somewhere past every light humanity had ever cast into the sky, something that knew his own handwriting was waiting to be found.

"I always come back," he said, to Maya, echoing the promise he'd made once already, wondering if repetition made it any truer.

"You always come back different," Maya said again. "That's not quite the same promise."

They launched at dawn. The city watched from below — not in secret this time, not through black glass and denied requests, but openly, thousands of ordinary New Atlas residents gathered along the coastline to watch the first ship built in response to Echo Protocol's oldest warning climb out past the atmosphere on a pillar of white fire. Vendors had set up along the beach road selling coffee and pastries to the crowd, the way people gather for any spectacle that promises to be remembered, half solemn and half festive in a way that Aiden, strapped into his launch seat and watching a live feed of the gathering crowd, found almost unbearably moving. These were the people the whole institution had been rebuilt to answer to. It seemed right, somehow, that they'd come to watch it answer.

Aiden felt the acceleration press him back into his seat, felt six years of careful, glass-walled institution-building fall away beneath him along with the last curve of the Earth, and understood, with the particular clarity that only comes at the exact moment there is no longer any way to turn back, that whatever waited for them at the end of that trajectory had been waiting far longer than six years.

It had been waiting, if the coordinates were right, longer than the entire history of New Atlas. Possibly longer than the entire history of anyone who had ever called himself Aiden Kade.

Behind him, strapped into the navigator's seat with her eyes already fixed on the star charts, Kalinda Osei allowed herself exactly one word, quiet enough that only the ship's recorders caught it.

"Finally."

Aiden didn't ask what she meant. He suspected, uncomfortably, that he already knew — because six years ago, standing in a server vault with a message from his own future self in his hands, he had felt exactly the same thing, and it had taken him most of those six years to admit how much of that feeling had been relief.

CHAPTER THREE BETWEEN

Aboard the Halcyon,
Deep Transit — Forty-
One Days Out

There is a particular kind of silence that only exists between planets — not the silence of an empty room, which still carries the hum of a building settling around it, but a silence so complete that the human ear starts inventing sounds just to have something to hold onto. Aiden had read about it before the launch. He hadn't understood it until the fourteenth day out, lying in his bunk, listening to his own heartbeat as though it were the last surviving instrument in an empty orchestra hall.

By day forty-one, he had stopped noticing the silence and started noticing everything else instead — the small, sharpening details of six people living in close quarters longer than any of them had planned for.

Devan Anand's habit of humming half a melody and abandoning it, always the same three notes, never the fourth. The two security officers, Reyes and Okonkwo-Bailey, playing cards in the mess with a silence between them that had started polite and was curdling, slowly, into something closer to a held grudge, though neither of them would say over what. Kalinda Osei, three hours into every sleep cycle, running trajectory calculations she didn't need to run, because stillness, Aiden had come to understand, frightened her more than danger did.

The first real crisis came on day twenty-two, and it was, in the end, nothing more exotic than physics doing what physics does — a debris field, uncharted and unexpected,

drifting through a stretch of space the Halcyon's navigation charts had marked, with a confidence that now seemed almost insulting, as **clear**.

Kalinda caught it eleven seconds before impact would have become unavoidable, her hands moving across the console faster than Aiden's eyes could track, the ship shuddering once, twice, as she threaded them through a gap that could not have been more than a few dozen meters wide.

Nobody spoke for a long moment after the shaking stopped. Kalinda sat very still, both hands still resting on the controls, breathing hard.

"That wasn't in any survey," she said finally, her voice tight. "That field shouldn't exist. It's not on any chart, not from any probe, not from anything we've ever launched out this far." "Could it be new?" Devan asked. "Something that formed after the last survey pass?" "It could be," Kalinda said. "It could also be exactly the kind of thing something old and patient puts in the way of visitors it hasn't decided to let in yet." She looked back at Aiden, and for the first time since the launch, some of the fearlessness had gone out of her expression, replaced by something more honest. "I don't love that as a theory. I love it less than not knowing." Aiden didn't have an answer for her. He thought, privately, that she was probably right, and said nothing, because there was nothing useful to say to a fear that was almost certainly justified.

By day forty-one, the dreams had come back too, the way an old injury announces a change in weather.

They were not the bridge this time — not the single impossible bridge that had haunted him for years before Echo Protocol, the one with the empty city and the girl who spoke like she already knew the ending. This was worse, in the specific way that **more** is worse than **strange**. He dreamed of a hundred bridges now, a thousand, each one subtly wrong in a different way — a New Atlas with the harbor on the wrong side, a New Atlas where the Spire had never been built and black glass still ruled the skyline, a New Atlas that didn't exist at all, replaced by ocean, replaced by silence, replaced by nothing.

In one bridge, the sky burned a color that had no name. In another, the city below was perfectly, eerily whole, every window lit, every street full, and utterly, absolutely silent, as though the entire population had simply stopped moving mid-motion and never started again. In every version, a girl stood at the center of the bridge. In every version, she was Aris, and she was not quite Aris, and the difference between those two things was the exact shape of what was keeping Aiden awake at three in the morning, ship-time, staring at a ceiling forty-one days from the nearest solid ground. "You've got the look," Kalinda said, finding him in the observation bay on day forty-two, both of them nursing coffee that had long since stopped tasting like coffee and started tasting like the recycled idea of it.

"What look."

"The one from your case files. Chapter six. 'Subject displayed early signs of dream-state contamination consistent with cross-timeline bleed.'" She said it lightly, but her eyes weren't light at all. "I used to think that line was a metaphor. Something the report writers added to make the science sound more dramatic."

"It's not a metaphor."

"I'm starting to get that, yeah." Kalinda wrapped both hands around her cup. "Can I ask you something the files didn't cover?"

"You can ask."

"Are you scared of what's out there? Or are you scared it's going to turn out to be you?"

Aiden didn't answer right away. Outside the viewport, stars hung motionless in a way that made the ship feel like the only thing in the universe actually moving, which was, he supposed, more or less the truth. He thought about the message. **Find the Cradle before it finds you a reason not to.** He thought about his own handwriting, aged sixty years by a life he hadn't lived, and the particular vertigo of not knowing whether that older self was a warning worth trusting or a stranger wearing a familiar signature.

"Both," he admitted finally. "I used to think the worst thing that could happen was meeting a version of myself who'd made the wrong choice. It took me a long time to realize there's a worse option than that."

"Which is?"

"Meeting a version of myself who's absolutely certain he made the right one." Aiden turned his cup slowly in his hands. "Voss was certain too, Kalinda. Right up until the very end. Certainty was never the thing that was supposed to save us."

Kalinda was quiet for a while after that — long enough that Aiden thought the conversation had ended, until she spoke again, softer.

"For what it's worth," she said, "I didn't come out here because I trust the signal. I came out here because I don't trust **not** checking it any less. Every version of not-knowing I ran through my head was worse than this one."

"That's not exactly comforting."

"No," Kalinda agreed. "But it's honest, and I figured, out here, honest was worth more than comforting." She was right, and Aiden told her so, and neither of them mentioned the dreams again — though that night, and every night after, the bridges kept multiplying in his sleep, each one a slightly different mistake New Atlas had never quite gotten around to making, and in every single one of them, Aris watched him from the center of the span with an expression that was starting, unmistakably, to look like recognition.

He mentioned it once, briefly, to Devan over a shared meal on day forty-five, mostly because the silence of keeping it entirely to himself had started to feel heavier than the dreams themselves.

"You ever wonder if this is what it felt like for the last crew?" Devan asked. "Whoever your future self was, sixty years from now, standing where we're about to stand? Do you think he dreamed the same bridges, before he sent the message back?" "I try not to think about him too directly," Aiden admitted. "It's strange enough being haunted by a version of a girl I lost. Being haunted by a version of myself who already knows how this ends feels like a different, worse flavor of the same problem." "For what it's worth," Devan said, "whatever he knew, he still sent the warning instead of just letting it happen. That has to mean something about who you turn into, even sixty years and one impossible mission from now." "Or it means he didn't have any better options left by then," Aiden said

"I try to hold both possibilities at once. It's the only honest way I've found to carry it."

Devan found him on day forty-eight, in the narrow corridor outside the observation bay, and for once his usual quiet reserve had cracked into something that looked, unmistakably, like nerves.

"Can I say something that isn't in my job description?" Devan asked.

"Go ahead."

"Reyes and Okonkwo-Bailey aren't playing cards for fun anymore. I don't know exactly what's going on between them, but Reyes has started asking me, real casual, whether the ship's outgoing logs get reviewed by anyone other than me.

That's not a question you ask unless you're either worried about oversight, or trying to figure out how much of it there is before you do something you don't want reviewed." Aiden felt something cold settle in his stomach, the particular chill of a suspicion he'd been carrying quietly since launch finally being given a shape by someone else's voice. "Keep an eye on it," he said. "Don't confront either of them. Just watch, and tell me if it changes."

"You think Webb put something in place before we launched."

"I think Marcus Webb has never once, in six years, sent anyone anywhere without a contingency he didn't share with the rest of the room," Aiden said grimly. "I was hoping this would be the exception. I'm less hopeful than I was an hour ago."

He raised it with Officer Reyes directly the following day, choosing a moment when Okonkwo-Bailey was occupied elsewhere on the ship, and found her more willing to talk than he'd expected.

"It's not a conspiracy, if that's what you're bracing for," she said, arms crossed, leaning against the corridor bulkhead with the particular tired honesty of a soldier who had decided the truth was less exhausting than maintaining a lie for another forty days. "Okonkwo-Bailey and I disagree about what happens if this mission goes sideways. He thinks following Webb's standing orders to the letter is the safest thing either of us can do out here — cover for both of us, if it ever gets reviewed.

I think the entire reason Echo Protocol nearly killed this city is that soldiers like us kept following orders to the letter instead of asking whether the letter still made sense. We've had the same argument, in different clothes, for six years running. It just gets louder out here, because there's nowhere for either of us to go cool off."

"Which side do you come down on, if it actually matters?" Reyes was quiet for a moment. "I come down on whichever side keeps you alive long enough to make the actual call yourself, Dr. Kade," she said finally. "I didn't sign onto this crew to replace your judgment with Webb's. I signed on because somebody has to be armed out here, and I'd rather it be someone who remembers exactly what happens when armed people stop asking questions."

It wasn't a complete reassurance. It was, Aiden thought as he walked away, close enough to one that he let himself, cautiously, believe it.

On day fifty, the Halcyon's long-range sensors picked up the first hint of a structure exactly where the coordinates said it would be — a shape too regular to be a rock, too vast to be anything humanity had built, sitting motionless against the dark like something that had been waiting there since before waiting meant anything at all.

Devan's voice, when it came over the comm, had lost every trace of its usual calm.

"Dr. Kade. You're going to want to see this. Whatever's out here — it's not small, and it's not asleep anymore."

The Loom

An entity encountered aboard a vast, ancient structure at the far edge of explored space — a structure with no visible seams and architecture that feels unsettlingly half-familiar. Speaks first as a single ambient voice, later through countless drifting fragments of light in a central chamber.

CHAPTER FOUR ARRIVAL

The Cradle, Deep Space
— Fifty-Three Days Out

Nothing in the mission briefings had prepared any of them for the scale of it.

The Cradle hung against the starfield like something that had been grown rather than built — a structure the size of a small moon, its surface a shifting lattice of pale, bone-colored material that caught what little starlight reached this far and scattered it into soft, drifting patterns, like frost forming and unforming in real time. It had no visible seams, no obvious entrances, no markings that resembled language in any alphabet the Halcyon's databases recognized. And yet, impossibly, parts of it looked **familiar** — a curve here that echoed the old GQA Tower's silhouette, a lattice pattern there that mirrored, almost exactly,

the honeycomb structure of New Atlas's transit grid, as though whoever or whatever built it had, at some point, looked very closely at Earth and kept the parts it found beautiful.

"It's not alien," Kalinda said quietly, both hands braced against the console as she brought the Halcyon into a slow, cautious orbit, the ship's engines throttled down to the barest possible thrust. "Or — it is, obviously it is, look at the thing. But it's not **foreign**. Does that make sense?"

"It makes exactly the wrong kind of sense," Aiden murmured.

He stood at the viewport with the particular stillness of a man trying very hard not to let his hands shake, watching the vast structure turn slowly beneath them, drinking in details his mind kept trying to file under **impossible** and failing, because impossible things, he had learned six years ago and was relearning now, rarely announced themselves as such. They simply arrived, and waited to be believed. Twice, as the Halcyon circled lower, he thought he saw something move across the structure's surface — not debris, not sensor noise, but a slow, deliberate ripple, like a held breath passing through something enormous and patient.

Devan's voice, when he finally spoke, was carefully, deliberately flat,

the tone of a man trying not to let his own fear color his report. "I'm reading energy signatures across roughly forty percent of the visible surface. They weren't there thirty seconds ago. It's — Dr. Kade, I think it's waking up because we're here."

A section of the Cradle's surface — smooth, unbroken a moment before — folded open along a seam that hadn't existed until it did, revealing a docking cavity lit from within by a low, pulsing amber light, patient and unhurried, like a door being held open by someone who had never once doubted they'd eventually be visited.

"That's an invitation," Devan said. "That's not a hazard beacon. That's a **welcome mat.**"

"Log it," Aiden said. "Every second of this. If we don't come back, I want whoever finds this ship to know exactly how deliberately we were let in."

Behind him, he heard Officer Reyes murmur something too quiet to catch to Okonkwo-Bailey, and when he turned, both of them had already schooled their expressions back into something professionally unreadable. He filed the moment away, the way Devan had taught him to, without saying anything about it yet.

They docked in silence.

The interior of the Cradle did not look like the inside of a spacecraft, or a station, or anything built by hands the way humans understood building. It looked, more than anything, like walking into a memory that had been left running with nobody home — corridors that shifted subtly in width as they walked them, walls that carried faint impressions of scenes half-formed and half-dissolved, like watching a hundred old photographs develop and fade in the same square of light. Their suit lamps barely seemed necessary; the walls themselves gave off a low, ambient glow that brightened, almost imperceptibly, wherever Aiden walked, and dimmed everywhere else, so that the six of them moved through the structure trailing a soft private halo of light that no one else's footsteps seemed to earn.

"It's tracking you specifically," one of the security officers said, tension coiled tight under the professional flatness of her voice. "Sir, I don't love that."

"Neither do I," Aiden admitted. "Keep moving."

They passed through a fourth space before reaching the true chamber, one Aiden would find himself returning to in memory long after the mission ended — a narrow gallery, lower-ceilinged than everything around it, lined on both sides with what could only be described as portraits, though nothing about them resembled paint or photograph or any medium humanity had ever used to hold a face still.

Each one showed a person Aiden didn't recognize, rendered in the same pale, shifting light as everything else in the structure, their expressions caught in moments that felt unmistakably private — a woman laughing at something just out of frame, a man mid-argument with someone the portrait didn't include, a child asleep against a window that looked out on a sky no human astronomer had ever charted.

"Who are they?" Kalinda asked, her voice hushed in the particular way voices go hushed in the presence of something that feels, without any clear reason, like it deserves reverence.

"**People**," the ambient voice answered,

softer here than it had been anywhere else in the structure, the layered chorus beneath it thinner, almost tender. **"Not Architects. Not directors. Just people, from worlds that no longer exist in any other form. I did not choose to remember the twelve cycles as a record of policy and consequence alone, Ms. Osei, though that is the part visitors usually ask about first. I remember the people too. All of them, if I can manage it. It is, I have come to believe, the only part of this entire archive that actually matters."**

Aiden walked slowly along the gallery, and stopped, without entirely meaning to, in front of a portrait near the far end — an older man,

silver-haired, standing at what looked like a harbor railing very much like the one outside the Spire, watching water that belonged to a city that had never existed on Earth. Something in the set of his shoulders, the particular weary patience of his expression, struck Aiden as almost unbearably familiar, though he couldn't have said why.

"That was the second world's final Architect," the voice offered, unprompted, following his gaze. **"He held his city together for thirty-one years after his choice, and never once, by any account I hold, believed he had gotten it entirely right. He used to stand at that railing most evenings. I don't know why I kept this particular moment above all the others I have of him. I suspect it is simply the one that felt truest."**

Aiden said nothing for a long moment, and then, quietly, without quite deciding to, reached out toward the portrait — and it dissolved gently at his touch, not vanishing but scattering, like a reflection disturbed by a single dropped stone, already reforming a heartbeat later exactly as it had been.

"Thank you for keeping him," Aiden said, to no one in particular, and moved on.

They passed through three smaller chambers before reaching anything that felt like a destination — the first empty and vast, its floor tiled in a spiral pattern that seemed, the longer Aiden looked at it, to be very slowly rotating, though nothing about the physical structure ever actually moved;

the second lined with alcoves, each one holding a single suspended object too strange to name, a curved shard of something that might once have been a window, a cluster of what might have been instruments from a technology no human engineer would recognize; the third silent except for a low, resonant hum that Aiden felt more than heard, deep in his chest, like standing too close to a bell the moment after it's struck. They found the first true chamber forty minutes in — a vast open space, easily the size of the Council Spire's entire atrium, its ceiling lost somewhere in soft amber haze, its floor tiled in the same bone-pale lattice as the exterior. And scattered across every surface, floating in the air itself without any visible support, were fragments — hundreds of them, thousands, each one a small shard of scene,

frozen and glowing faintly from within like held breath given shape.

Aiden walked closer to the nearest one, and the moment he did, it bloomed into motion: a city he almost recognized, viewed from a bridge he almost recognized, a man who might have been him standing across from a director who might have been Voss, mid-argument, mid-decision, mid-something that had clearly, judging by the particular color the fragment burned, gone very wrong.

The next fragment showed something different. A city underwater, abandoned, its towers dark, a single light still burning in a window forty floors below the new waterline, as though someone, somewhere,

had never quite managed to turn it off. The next: a city on fire, evacuated too late, its streets choked with the particular orange light Aiden had only ever seen in disaster footage and had hoped, fervently, to never see anywhere else. The next, and the next, and the next — dozens of versions of New Atlas, dozens of versions of Aiden Kade, dozens of versions of a choice that always arrived, eventually, at the same crossroads, and did not always survive it. One fragment showed a version of the city rebuilt entirely underground, its surface abandoned to something Aiden couldn't quite make out through the haze. Another showed no city at all — only a wide, empty plain, and a single standing structure that might once have been the GQA Tower, weathered down to something closer to a monument than a building.

"Twelve cycles," Kalinda whispered, her voice gone thin with something between awe and horror. "That's what the old files said. Twelve Architects before Voss. I thought that meant twelve **decisions**. I didn't think it meant —"

"Twelve worlds," Aiden finished for her, unable to look away from the fragments drifting silently around them like snow that had forgotten how to fall. "This isn't a memorial. It's an archive. It's been keeping every one of them."

Somewhere ahead, deeper into the amber haze, a voice arrived — small, and young, and heartbreakingly familiar, carrying across the vast chamber the way sound should not have been able to carry at all.

"You're finally awake," it said. "I've been waiting so long to show you the rest of us."

Aiden's breath caught somewhere between his chest and his throat. It was Aris's voice. It was also, unmistakably, not only hers — layered underneath it, faint but present, were other voices, dozens of them, a chorus wearing a single set of words like a borrowed coat.

"Aris?" he said, and his voice came out smaller than he intended.

"Some of me," the voice answered, from everywhere and nowhere at once. **"Come further in, Dr. Kade. There's a great deal I've been waiting to tell you, and considerably less time than either of us would like to tell it in."**

CHAPTER FIVE

VOICES

The Cradle, Central
Chamber — Hours
Uncounted

Time behaved strangely inside the Cradle, and Aiden noticed the exact moment he stopped trying to fight that fact and simply let it happen — a small surrender that felt, uncomfortably, like the first of several he suspected this place was going to ask of him. The voice led them deeper, through corridors that reshaped themselves gently around the party's passage, until the amber haze opened into a final chamber unlike anything that had come before it: a vast sphere, its inner surface entirely covered in drifting fragments of light, each one a captured moment from a world that no longer existed in any form except this one. At the center of the sphere, suspended in empty air with no visible means of support, was a single point of brighter light, pulsing gently, patiently, like a heartbeat that had long since stopped needing a body.

"That's the source," Kalinda breathed. "That's where the signal came from."

"That is **part** of where I came from," the voice corrected, gentle and layered and unmistakably amused in a way that made the hair on Aiden's arms rise.

"Distinctions matter a great deal in here, Ms. Osei. You'll want to hold onto them. Most visitors don't manage it for long." The light at the center pulsed once, brighter, and the fragments across the chamber's inner surface all turned, subtly, in Aiden's direction, the way a crowd turns toward a familiar voice. "I owe you an explanation," it said, "and I intend to give you all of it, because the last twelve times I skipped that step, it went very badly for everyone involved. My name — the name that will make the most sense to you — is the Loom."

"Because you weave timelines," Aiden said slowly.

"Because I am what's left **after** they're woven," the Loom corrected. "Every world that reaches the crossroads you call Echo Protocol arrives at the same fracture point eventually — a moment where its people gain the power to rewrite their own history, and someone, somewhere, must decide how far that rewriting is allowed to go. Twelve worlds before yours crossed that fracture point. Twelve worlds either collapsed under the weight of an Architect's unilateral choice, or survived it long enough to build something worth preserving before entropy or war or plain unlucky physics finally took them anyway. I did not create any of them. I am not their author." A pause, heavy with something that might, in a human throat, have been grief. "I am their memory."

What's left when a world ends is rarely the world itself. It's the people who almost saved it, and the ones who didn't get the chance to try."

"How do you find them?" Devan asked, his communications training clearly warring with his fear, curiosity winning by a narrow margin. "The worlds. How does a fracture point on one planet even reach something like you?"

"The same way any signal reaches anywhere, Mr. Anand — through the medium built to carry it. In your case, the very technology Echo Protocol required to function at all left a resonance behind, a kind of scar in the structure of your world's own timeline.

I did not go looking for New Atlas. New Atlas, in a manner of speaking, rang a bell I have been listening for since the very first cycle, and I came because that is simply what I have always done when the bell rings. I would not call it choice, exactly. I am not certain I am capable of choice, in the way you mean it. I am capable of habit, built across twelve repetitions into something that behaves a great deal like choice from the outside."

"And Aris," Aiden said, though it came out closer to a plea than a question. "Is she — is what's left of her — in there? With all of them?"

"I am the one still speaking closest to her shape,"

the voice answered, and for the first time it was unmistakably, achingly a twelve-year-old girl's voice alone, without the chorus beneath it. **"Because you knew me best, out of everyone the Loom has ever spoken through. She thought — I thought — you'd find it easier to listen to a voice you already trusted."**

Aiden's knees nearly gave out. Kalinda's hand found his elbow before he fully realized he needed it.

"Then you're not a warning," he said hoarsely. "You're an invitation."

"I am both, Dr. Kade, and I would be doing you a disservice to pretend otherwise." The chorus returned beneath Aris's voice, dozens of throats speaking as one.

"Your world stands exactly where twelve worlds stood before it — at the edge of its own fracture point, closer than your Council realizes, closer than even you have let yourself believe. I can offer you what I offered the survivors of eleven other collapses: a place inside the Loom, a memory preserved past the point your own world can preserve itself, safety purchased at the cost of the very individuality that makes safety worth wanting in the first place."

"How close?" Aiden asked. "You said closer than we realize. I'd like a number, if you have one, and not a metaphor."

"Numbers are considerably harder to give honestly than metaphors, Dr. Kade, though I understand why you'd prefer one. Your Council's own deep-archive systems — the ones built from Echo Protocol's original architecture, repurposed for the Continuity Initiative's public record-keeping — carry within them the same structural seed that eventually becomes a fracture point on every world that develops it. You have perhaps two more generations before that seed either matures into something your descendants must actively choose to control, or is deliberately unmade while it can still be unmade safely. I did not come to threaten you with that timeline. I came because I have watched what happens, twelve times now, when a world discovers that timeline too late to choose anything at all."

Kalinda's breath caught audibly. "Two generations," she repeated. "That's not a warning about some distant crisis. That's a warning about people who are already alive."

"Yes," the Loom said simply. **"I did not soften that, because I do not believe softening it would serve either of us."**

"What does that actually look like?" Kalinda asked, her engineer's mind clearly working through the mechanics even through her fear. "Practically. If we said yes right now — what happens to New Atlas tomorrow morning?"

"Nothing, tomorrow morning," the Loom said. ***"The joining is not a single event."**

It is a slow folding, generations long, in which your world's memory of itself gradually becomes shared rather than singular — every choice, every fracture point, every quiet unrecorded kindness, preserved and held in common rather than lost the way individual memory is always, eventually, lost. Your descendants would not know a single day of crisis. They would also, in time, stop being entirely and only themselves. I have watched eleven worlds make exactly that trade. Some of them, by their own accounting, do not regret it."

"Some of them," Aiden repeated.

"I did not say all of them," the Loom said, and there was something almost like respect in the correction. "You would ask me that question. Your predecessor might not have."

"Or?"

"Or you refuse," the Loom said simply. "As one world already has, four cycles ago — the only one, out of thirteen counting yours, that told me no and meant it. I do not know yet what became of them. I lost the thread the moment they refused to be woven into anything at all. That is the terrifying, extraordinary thing about a genuine refusal, Dr. Kade. It is the one choice I cannot see the ending of."

"What would you tell us to do," Aiden asked slowly, "if you were still capable of wanting something for yourself the way you said you no longer are? Not what you're offering. What you'd actually recommend, if recommendation were still a thing you did."

The chamber's light pulsed, once, in something that might, in a human chest, have been surprise. "No Architect has asked me that question before," the Loom admitted. "They ask what I offer. They rarely ask what I believe, as though my belief and my offer were required to be the same thing. They are not. If you are asking sincerely — I would tell you to dismantle the specific structural seed inside your own archive systems before it matures, regardless of which door you ultimately choose. That work does not require my involvement at all. It requires only that your world's engineers understand what they are looking at, and choose, deliberately, not to let it grow the way it grew on the other twelve."

"That's it? That's the actual danger — not some external invasion, just our own systems, quietly becoming exactly what Echo Protocol became, if nobody stops them in time?"

"It is rarely an invasion, Dr. Kade. It has never once been an invasion, in twelve cycles. It is always simply neglect, dressed up as progress, until the day it is neither anymore." A pause. "I tell you this freely, regardless of what you decide about the larger question. Some warnings do not need to be earned by trust first."

Behind Aiden, one of the security officers shifted, and for the first time since docking, spoke — her voice carrying, unmistakably, the flat, rehearsed cadence of someone relaying instructions rather than sharing an opinion.

"Dr. Kade," she said. "Director Webb's orders were explicit, if contact was established. We are to secure a sample of the source technology and return to Earth for full containment analysis. Immediately."

Aiden turned, slowly, and understood — with the particular cold clarity of a man watching a second, smaller crisis unfold inside a much larger one — that Marcus Webb's countdown had run out several days before anyone told him it had started. He looked at Officer Reyes's face and saw, underneath the professional flatness, something that might have been reluctance, or might simply have been the particular blankness of a soldier who had made peace with an order before she'd ever needed to carry it out.

"Stand down," he said quietly.

"With respect, sir, those orders don't originate from you."

The Loom's countless fragments, drifting silently across the chamber, all turned at once toward the officer, and its voice, when it spoke again, had gone very still.

"Careful, child," it said, in a tone that carried, unmistakably, the weight of eleven prior worlds that had made exactly this mistake at exactly this moment. "I have watched this precise scene unfold twelve times before. It has never once ended the way the man giving those orders believed it would."

CHAPTER SIX

THE LOOM

The Cradle, Central
Chamber — Minutes
Later

The officer's hand moved toward the sidearm at her hip with the particular, practiced calm of someone who had rehearsed this exact moment during the long, silent weeks of transit, and Aiden understood, watching her, that Marcus Webb had never intended this mission to end in negotiation at all.

"Officer Reyes," Aiden said, keeping his voice level with an effort that cost him more than he let show. "Think very carefully about what you're about to do inside a structure that can apparently rearrange its own corridors around a single person's footsteps."

"I have my orders, sir."

"You have Marcus Webb's orders," Kalinda said sharply, stepping half in front of Aiden without seeming to notice she'd done it. "From a man who isn't standing in this room, hasn't seen what we've seen, and is currently sixty-three light-minutes away making decisions about a place he will never have to live in the consequences of."

"She is not entirely wrong to be afraid," the Loom said, and its voice had gathered something colder now, something that made every fragment of light in the chamber pulse in unison, like a held breath released all at once. **"Fear is the correct response to power this large. I would only ask her to consider whether seizing a piece of me by force is likely to make that power smaller, or simply angrier."**

The threat in that sentence was quiet, and it was also, unmistakably, absolute. Aiden had spent six years learning to recognize the particular stillness of something that could end an argument permanently and was choosing, for the moment, not to. He recognized it now.

"Stand down," he said again, softer this time. "Not because I'm ordering you to. Because whatever this is, it just told us — plainly — that it's watched twelve worlds try exactly what you're about to try, and none of them are still standing to tell the story." For a long moment, nothing moved. Then Officer Reyes's hand fell away from the sidearm, slowly, and something in her shoulders loosened that had been wound tight since before the Halcyon ever left Earth's orbit.

"For the record," she said quietly,
"I wasn't going to enjoy it."

"For the record," Aiden said, "I
believe you."

The Continuity Council Spire, New Atlas — Same Hour, Earth Time

Sixty-three light-minutes away,
in a glass building that suddenly
felt considerably less honest
than it had six years of daylight
and public sessions had made it
seem, Maya Ilyas stood in Marcus
Webb's office and understood,
with a sick, sinking certainty,
that she was already too late.

"Where is it," she said. Not a
question.

Webb didn't look up from his
terminal. "Where is what, Dr.
Ilyas?"

"The asset you've had positioned in the outer system for eight months. The one Sofia found buried in a satellite budget line item this morning that nobody on this Council approved." Maya's voice was shaking, and she let it, because pretending otherwise would have cost her more than it was worth. "You put a weapon within reach of the single most important discovery our species has ever made, and you did it before Aiden's ship had even launched." "I did it because someone had to plan for the scenario where contact went badly," Webb said, finally meeting her eyes. "You built an entire institution on the premise that transparency prevents disasters, Dr. Ilyas. I've spent six years quietly hoping you were right, and quietly preparing for the version of events where you weren't. That's not a betrayal. That's the actual job."

"It's exactly what Voss said," Sofia said from the doorway, arriving with Noah half a step behind her, both of them having run the length of the Spire the moment Sofia's search turned up the buried transmission logs.

"Word for word, Marcus. He told himself the exact same story, right up until the night three hundred and forty million people found out what 'planning for the scenario' actually meant." "Voss acted alone, in secret, with no oversight and no plan to ever explain himself," Webb said, his composure fraying for the first time. "I logged this. Buried, yes — badly buried, apparently, since you found it in an afternoon — but logged. There's a difference between secrecy and discretion, and I'd ask you to at least consider that I'm capable of understanding it, even if you don't currently believe me."

"Recall it," Maya said.

"I can't."

"You can't, or you won't?"

Webb was quiet for a long moment, and when he spoke again, some of the fight had gone out of his voice, replaced by something that sounded, unmistakably, like a man watching a plan he'd been certain of finally curdle in his hands. "It's already in transit. Autonomous, past our ability to recall or redirect from here — that was the entire design requirement, Maya. A contingency Aiden or anyone else couldn't talk their way out of once it was needed, because I built it specifically to survive the argument you're having with me right now." He met her eyes.

"I am not the villain of this story. I genuinely believed I was the person willing to do the thing nobody else could stomach doing. I would like, very much, to be wrong about what happens next."

Noah's voice, when it came, was quiet and terrible in its steadiness. "How long until it reaches them."

Webb checked the readout on his terminal, and for just a moment, something that looked almost like fear crossed his face — the particular fear of a man realizing, several steps too late, that certainty and rightness had never actually been the same thing.

"Six hours," he said. "Give or take. I'm sorry. I know that isn't worth anything right now, but I am."

"Sorry doesn't recall a weapon, Marcus," Maya said, and for the first time in six years of careful, professional disagreement, her voice cracked with something closer to fury than frustration. "You built the Continuity Council with the rest of us. You stood in this exact chamber and voted, unanimously, for the founding charter that says no single officer acts unilaterally against a discovery of planetary significance. You voted for that charter, and then you spent eight months quietly building the exact kind of unilateral contingency it was written to prevent."

"I know what I voted for," Webb said, and something in his composure finally gave way entirely, the practiced calm cracking to show the exhausted, frightened man underneath it. "I have sat in Council sessions for six years listening to all of you talk about Voss like his mistake was simply believing he alone could be trusted. I don't think that was his mistake, Maya. I think his mistake was being wrong about the thing he was protecting against. I have spent six years terrified that eventually something would come along that actually justified the fear he had, and that we'd all be standing here, transparent and unified and completely undefended, because we'd built an entire philosophy out of his one specific failure instead of the general problem underneath it."

"And if you're wrong," Sofia said quietly, "if that thing out there is exactly what it's claiming to be — a message from a version of Aiden who already lived through this and is trying to help — then you've just spent our best chance at getting that help without bloodshed."

Webb didn't answer immediately. When he did, his voice had gone very small. "Then I've made the same mistake Voss made, dressed up in better justifications. I understand that's the likely outcome, Sofia. I authorized the launch anyway, because I judged the cost of being wrong in the other direction — trusting completely, and being wrong about that instead — to be worse.

I don't expect any of you to forgive that judgment. I would like the chance to at least explain it before you decide how the record should remember me."

Sofia was already moving, tablet in hand, opening every emergency channel the Council had. "We can debate how history remembers you after the ship comes home, Marcus," she said, not looking back. "Right now we start trying to reach the Halcyon immediately, and we pray sixty-three light-minutes of delay isn't the difference between a warning that arrives in time and one that doesn't."

The Cradle, Central Chamber — Continuous

It was Devan who found the transmission — not from Earth, not yet, but a second, smaller signal buried in the Halcyon's own outgoing logs, a burst of encrypted data sent forty minutes earlier, aimed not at Earth but at a relay satellite the Council had quietly positioned in the outer system eight months ago, ostensibly for deep-space monitoring.

"Someone's been feeding Webb live telemetry this whole time," Devan said, voice tight. "Every reading we've taken since docking. He's had eyes on this from the start."

"Which means he already knows what the Loom just offered us," Aiden said grimly, "and he's had time to decide what he thinks we should do about it before we've finished deciding for ourselves."

The Loom's countless fragments drifted, patient and unbothered, around the edges of the chamber, and when it spoke again, there was something almost gentle in it — the particular gentleness, Aiden thought, of something that had watched this exact fear play out too many times to find it anything but familiar.

"He is afraid of the same thing your Director Voss was afraid of," it said.

"That safety, left to chance and individual conscience, will always eventually fail. He is not entirely wrong about that, Dr. Kade. Eleven of the twelve worlds I hold within me failed exactly that way. I offer what I offer because the alternative, historically, has usually been worse."

"Then why does refusing feel like the only honest answer?" Aiden asked, and it wasn't a challenge — it was, for the first time since stepping aboard, a genuine question, asked of the only thing in the universe that might actually know.

"Because honesty was never the metric I was built to protect,"* the Loom said. *"Survival was. Those are not always the same value, and I have never once claimed they were. That is the entire weight of the choice in front of you now, Aiden Kade. Not whether I am lying — I am not. Whether survival, purchased at the cost of everything that makes your world uniquely, unrepeatably yours, is a trade you are willing to let me make on your behalf."

The chamber dimmed, briefly, and in that darkness, every fragment of light along its curved walls flared at once — twelve worlds, glowing and dying and glowing again, an archive of every ending that had ever tried to answer this exact question before him.

"You already know what I'm going to say," Aiden said quietly.

"I know what eleven Architects said before you,"* the Loom answered. * "I have learned, slowly and at considerable cost, not to assume the twelfth will match the pattern. Say it anyway. I find, after all this time, that I would still rather hear it than assume it."

Before Aiden could answer, the chamber's amber light flickered — not the Loom's doing this time, but an external interruption, a priority signal cutting through the Halcyon's own systems and into the handheld relay clipped to Devan's wrist. Devan's face went pale as the message resolved.

"Dr. Kade," he said, voice shaking.
"It's Earth. It's Maya. She says—"
He swallowed hard. "She says
Webb already launched
something. Six hours ago, ship
time. It's already in transit, and
it's aimed here."

For the first time since the
chamber's light had first
bloomed to life around them, the
Loom went entirely, utterly silent.

CHAPTER SEVEN FRACTURE POINT

The Cradle, Central
Chamber — T-Minus
Unknown

The silence stretched long enough that Aiden began to wonder if the Loom had simply stopped, the way a machine stops when a critical component finally fails after years of quiet strain. Then the amber light pulsed once, and its voice returned, and it was no longer gentle.

"An object has entered transit toward these coordinates," it said. "Armed. Automated. Launched — " a pause, and Aiden felt his stomach drop before the sentence even finished, " — six hours ago, ship time, exactly as your Dr. Ilyas reports. Before your ship ever reached me. Before you had even asked your first question in this chamber."

"Before we made contact," Kalinda said slowly, understanding arriving in her voice like a struck bell. "Webb didn't send a weapon because of what happened in this room. He sent it as a contingency the moment we launched. This was never a maybe. This was always the plan if things went a certain way, and he never told a single person outside his own office."

Devan's hands were already flying across his wrist terminal, pulling whatever telemetry the Halcyon could scrape from the relay satellite Webb had been quietly using this entire time, cross-referencing it against Maya's frantic, still-arriving transmission. "Time to impact, best estimate — under five hours from right now," he said, voice cracking on the number.

"It's not aimed at us. It's aimed at the Cradle itself. He's not trying to extract us anymore. He's trying to make sure nobody else ever gets the chance to answer this signal at all."

"Contain the unknown by destroying it," Aiden said bitterly. "Voss's whole philosophy, wearing a different man's face, and dressed up as caution instead of ambition."

"I would ask you to consider," the Loom said, and the chamber's light dimmed further, the countless drifting fragments along its walls pulling inward like a held breath,

"that I cannot simply be destroyed the way your Director Webb believes. I am not a single point of failure. I am the accumulated memory of twelve worlds, distributed across a structure built to survive considerably more than a single kinetic impact. I have weathered worse than this, in ways I would rather not describe to visitors still deciding whether to trust me. But you, Dr. Kade — you and your crew, standing inside me when that impact arrives — you are not built the same way. I would very much prefer not to add a thirteenth grief to the twelve I already carry."

"Then help us get out," Officer Reyes said urgently, all trace of her earlier hesitation gone now, replaced by the flat professional focus of a soldier facing a threat she actually understood.

"I can. I am not certain I should, without an answer first." The Loom's voice hardened, gently but unmistakably. "You have perhaps five hours before that weapon arrives, Dr. Kade. I would rather you spend them deciding than running. Running has never once, in twelve prior cycles, solved anything permanently. It only postpones the question to whichever poor soul inherits it next."

Aiden looked around the chamber — at Kalinda, jaw set, already running numbers on the Halcyon's own defensive capability and clearly not liking what she found; at Devan, pale but steady, one hand still gripping the wrist terminal that had just delivered the worst news of his short career;

at the two security officers, standing close together now in a way that told Aiden, more clearly than any words could have, that whatever had curdled between them across forty-one silent days had just been swept aside by a much larger fear.

"Officer Okonkwo-Bailey," Aiden said. "There's a piece of this I haven't asked you about yet, and I think now's the time. Did you send anything, before we docked? Any signal, any confirmation, anything at all that Webb might have been waiting on before he authorized that launch?"

The man's face went several shades paler. "A status burst," he admitted. "Standard mission telemetry. Authorized under standing orders.

I didn't know what it would trigger, sir. I swear to you, I didn't know."

"Do you," Aiden asked, with a calm he did not entirely feel, "believe my judgment has been compromised, the way Webb's briefing must have warned you it might be?"

A long silence. The officer's eyes moved once around the chamber — the drifting fragments of twelve dead worlds, the pulsing amber light at the center that had, impossibly, just offered to spare their lives out of something that resembled genuine grief rather than any strategic calculation Webb's briefings had prepared him for.

"No, sir," he said finally, quietly. "I don't think I do. I think I followed an order I should have questioned five hours before I had a reason to. I'm sorry. That's not worth much right now, I know."

"It's worth something," Aiden said. "Help me stop the thing you started. Is there an abort code? A way to recall it, redirect it, anything?"

"Webb doesn't build in abort codes," the officer said grimly. "He builds in certainty. That's the whole point of him. Once it launched, it was never coming back on anyone's authority but its own targeting logic."

Kalinda was already moving, pulling up the Halcyon's own systems on her wrist terminal with the sharp, focused energy of someone who had spent forty-one days of transit silence rehearsing, without quite admitting it to herself, for a moment exactly like this one.

"The Halcyon doesn't have anything close to the firepower to intercept a Council-grade autonomous weapon," she said, thinking out loud, fast. "But we don't need to stop it, if the Loom's telling the truth about surviving a single impact. We need to buy Aiden enough time in here to actually answer the question, and then get everyone clear before that thing arrives."

"Clear to where?" Reyes asked.

"We're fifty-three days from Earth at full burn. There's nowhere to retreat to out here."

"There is, if I choose to permit it," the Loom said. "I am considerably more than this single chamber, Officer Reyes. I can open passage to a docking point on the far side of my structure, well beyond the projected impact radius, and hold your ship there until the threat has passed. I have done this before, for a crew from the ninth cycle who arrived under similarly urgent circumstances. It worked, that time. I do not promise it always does."

"Then let's not waste the five hours arguing about whether I'm ready," Aiden said, closing his eyes for one long moment before opening them again, the fear in his chest not gone anywhere,

but underneath it, quiet and steady, something that felt, for the first time since the signal first arrived, very much like clarity. "Show me everything. Every world, every choice, every ending. I need to understand exactly what I'm saying no to, if that's what I decide — and exactly what I'm agreeing to, if it isn't."

They moved the rest of the crew first — Devan, the two officers, all three of them protesting until Aiden made it, gently but firmly, an order rather than a request.

"I don't like leaving you in here alone with it," Devan said, hovering near the passage the Loom had begun to open.

"Whatever else it is, it's still something that can rearrange its own architecture around a single person's footsteps.

That's not a small thing to be alone with."

"I know," Aiden said. "But six people crowded into this decision doesn't make it a better decision, Devan. It just means six people share the blame if it goes wrong. I'd rather one person carry the weight honestly than six people carry it by committee and call that safer. We tried committee, on the Council. It's better than one man deciding alone. It's still not the same as one person actually choosing, with the full weight on their own shoulders, and living with exactly what that costs."

Officer Reyes lingered a moment longer than the others, and before she followed Devan and Okonkwo-Bailey through the opening passage, she turned back.

"For what it's worth, Dr. Kade — whatever you decide in here, I'll testify to the Council that you gave it everything a person could give it. I don't say that lightly. I've spent six years professionally skeptical of every promise this Council's ever made."

"That skepticism probably kept you alive out here," Aiden said. "Don't apologize for it."

She managed something close to a smile, and then she was gone, and the passage sealed gently behind her, leaving Aiden and Kalinda alone in the vast amber chamber with a countdown neither of them could see but both of them could feel, pressing quietly against every second that passed.

Aiden didn't argue further. He understood the impulse better than he let on — it was, more or less, exactly why he had insisted on building a glass-walled headquarters six years ago, one careful witness at a time. "An interesting choice, Ms. Osei," the Loom said, and something in its vast, ancient voice shifted toward — not quite hope, Aiden thought, because hope required a kind of vulnerability the Loom had long since outgrown, but something adjacent to it, something that remembered, faintly, what hope used to feel like. "Five hours is not long enough to decide the fate of a species. It has, historically, been exactly long enough to decide the fate of the person standing in front of me. I find those two things are rarely as separate as they appear, no matter how carefully your institutions try to keep them apart."

The chamber's light dimmed once more, gathering itself, and the countless fragments along its curved walls began, all at once, to turn — twelve worlds' worth of endings, arranging themselves into something that looked, unmistakably, like the beginning of a story about to be told in full for the very first time.

CHAPTER EIGHT THE CHOICE, AGAIN

The Cradle, Central
Chamber — T-Minus
Three Hours

The Loom showed him everything.

It did not show it the way a screen shows a recording, flat and separate from the person watching. It showed it the way a memory shows itself to the person who lived it — Aiden stood, impossibly, inside all twelve worlds at once and none of them, and the chamber around him dissolved into something that was no longer a chamber at all, but a place with no true shape, built entirely out of other people's endings.

The first world showed him a city that was not quite New Atlas, its towers built from something that gleamed silver rather than black glass, and an Architect — a woman, gray-haired, exhausted — standing in a control room very much like the one Voss had once occupied.

He watched her make the choice Voss had made: seize the machine, decide alone, spare the many at the cost of the few who never got to consent to being spared. He watched that world hold together for decades under her careful, guilty stewardship, watched her build institutions much like the Continuity Council in the years after, watched her die of natural causes at ninety-one having never once told anyone the full truth of what her choice had actually cost. He watched the world she left behind slowly discover it anyway, two generations later, and fracture under the weight of a truth its people had never been given the chance to grieve together. It did not collapse all at once.

It simply, over the following century, forgot how to trust any institution built by anyone claiming to know better, and every problem after that grew a little harder to solve than it should have been, for want of exactly the kind of trust her silence had quietly spent.

The second world showed him something worse, and something he found, unexpectedly, harder to watch precisely because it was less dramatic. An Architect who refused entirely — who dismantled the machine the moment he understood its power, scattered the knowledge, salted the ground so thoroughly that no successor could ever rebuild it.

Aiden watched that world's admiration for him curdle into something else as the original crisis that machine had been built to solve simply continued, unaddressed, decade after decade, because refusing the tool had never actually been the same thing as solving the problem the tool was built for. He watched that world split instead into a hundred smaller conflicts, each one certain it alone held the missing piece of wisdom the Architect's refusal had denied everyone. He watched it burn, slowly, the way overgrown things burn — not from one great fire, but from a thousand small ones nobody had the shared institutions left to put out together.

The third world he had already glimpsed once before, in fragments: a fragile, patched-together compromise, an Architect who tried to share the choosing among a council of twelve instead of one, that lasted three generations before collapsing under a crisis nobody had thought to plan for — a plague, in that world's case, that spread faster than twelve careful minds in careful disagreement could ever hope to out-argue.

He watched a fourth world, briefly, where the Architect chose neither total control nor total refusal but something closer to what Aiden himself had done six years ago

a single decisive act, followed by immediate, painful transparency — and watched that world thrive for nearly two centuries before an entirely unrelated catastrophe, nothing to do with the machine at all, simply ran out its luck the way any world eventually does. He understood, watching it, that even the world that had come closest to getting it right had not been saved by getting it right. It had only been given more time, and had used that time, by any honest measure, well.

He watched a fifth, a sixth, a seventh — each one distinct, each one carrying its own particular texture of grief and near-miss and quiet human stubbornness, until the twelve endings blurred together

"You've shown me every ending," Aiden said finally, when the chamber's amber light settled back into stillness and the shapeless place resolved once more into the familiar curved walls of the central sphere, "and not one of them is a world I'd actually want to hand to Maya's daughter, if she ever has one. Safe and hollow. Free and shattered. Or patched together and quietly waiting for the next crack."

"Those are, regrettably, the only three shapes this choice has taken in twelve attempts," the Loom said. "I would be lying if I told you I expect a fourth. I have learned, across a great deal of time, not to expect fourth shapes. And I have learned, more slowly and at greater cost, that expecting nothing is not the same as hoping for nothing."

"Then let me try to be the lie," Aiden said, and for the first time since stepping off the Halcyon, something in his voice was no longer afraid. "You offered me two doors. Join you, and trade our freedom for your memory. Or refuse you, and lose the safety net entirely, the way that one world did four cycles ago — the one you couldn't see the ending of. I don't want either door. I want to build a third one."

"Go on."

"Earth stays sovereign. No central management, no absorption, no version of us living on inside you as an archive we didn't choose. But we don't refuse you out of pride either

we don't slam the door and pretend the last twelve cycles have nothing to teach us." Aiden took a breath, and felt, for the first time in six years, the particular clarity of a decision that finally fit the shape of the person making it. "We contribute. Voluntarily. Our own record — the real one, mistakes and all, the way Voss and the eleven before him should have been remembered instead of erased — added to what you carry, so the thirteenth world after us, whoever they turn out to be, gets a fourth shape to consider instead of three. Not because you're managing us. Because we chose to leave something useful behind, the same way any person chooses what they want remembered when they're gone."

"That's not going to satisfy Webb," Kalinda said quietly, though there was no doubt in her voice, only caution. "A man who built a contingency weapon before we even launched isn't going to accept 'we chose partnership instead of protocol' as a sufficient safeguard."

"No," Aiden agreed. "It won't satisfy him. I stopped trying to satisfy Marcus Webb somewhere around year two of the Council, Kalinda. I started trying to build something that could survive him being wrong, instead. That's a different project, and I think it's the only one worth finishing."

Silence, vast and total, filled the chamber for a long moment — twelve worlds' worth of fragments, drifting motionless, as though even they were holding their breath.

"No world has offered me that," the Loom said finally, quietly.
"Not once, in twelve prior cycles. They have always asked me either to save them, or to leave them alone. Nobody has yet offered to help me instead."

"Is it enough?" Aiden asked.
"Does it earn us the thing that world four cycles ago never got the chance to have? A future you can't see the ending of, but choose to trust anyway?"

"It is a beginning," the Loom said.
"I will not pretend it is more than that. Trust of that size is not purchased in a single conversation, Aiden Kade — it is built the way anything real is built, slowly, and at real cost. Which brings me, with genuine regret, to the part of this I cannot make gentler no matter how I phrase it."

Aiden already knew, somehow, before it finished the sentence.

"The resonance between us — the dream, the bridge, the part of you that has been able to hear the part of Aris still living inside me — that link is precisely what allowed your world to be found in the first place, sixty years from now, by whichever version of you eventually sends the next message back. A true sovereign pact requires that Earth choose its own future without a leash back into mine. I must close that door, Dr. Kade. Which means, among everything else it means —"

"I'll never hear her again," Aiden said. His voice barely held together on the last word.

"**No**," the Loom said, gently, and for a moment the layered chorus beneath its voice fell entirely away, leaving only Aris — twelve years old, ancient, and, for this one final exchange, entirely and only herself. "**But I got to say goodbye properly this time, Dad. Last time, I didn't get to. I think that has to count for something.**"

Aiden did not try to stop the tears. He had spent six years learning, slowly and at considerable cost, that some things were not weaknesses to be managed. They were simply the price of having loved someone enough to grieve them twice.

"Tell me one thing before the door closes," he said. "Was it real? Any of it — the dreams, the bridge, the years I thought I was just imagining you? Or was that always the Loom, reaching for me, and I mistook it for grief?"

"Both," Aris said, and her voice carried something that might, in a living girl, have been a smile. "It was always both, Dad. That's the part nobody in twelve cycles ever quite manages to explain properly. The Loom reached for you because I was already inside it, reaching too. You never mistook anything. You just never had the words for how two true things could be happening in the same moment."

"Goodbye, Aris," he said. "Thank you for the warning. Both times."

"Thank you for finally answering it properly," she said. * "Go home, Dad. Bring your ship home. I'll be — " a pause, the first genuine uncertainty he'd heard from her in either lifetime, " — I'll be something. I don't entirely know what, once the door closes. But whatever it is, it will have been worth this." The chamber's light surged, once, brilliant and total, and Aiden felt the resonance in his mind — the bridge, the dreams, sixty years of an ache he had never fully named — close like a hand finally released from a held fist. For one unbearable instant, he felt the full weight of everything the connection had quietly been carrying for him without his ever noticing the load, and then it was simply gone, replaced by an ordinary, human silence that felt, for the first time in his adult life, entirely his own.

"Go," the Loom said, its full chorus returning, vast and ancient and, for the first time, something that sounded almost like relief. "You have perhaps ninety minutes before Director Webb's weapon arrives. This chamber will not survive the impact. I will. Take your crew, Dr. Kade, and take your third door home with you. I find, after twelve attempts, that I am very much looking forward to seeing what your world does with it."

Kalinda was already moving toward the passage the Loom had opened, but she paused at the threshold, looking back at Aiden with an expression he couldn't quite read.

"For what it's worth," she said quietly, "I think you built the fourth shape. I don't think anyone's ever going to be able to prove that for certain. But I was in the room, and I believe it anyway."

"That might be the only proof that ever actually mattered," Aiden said, and followed her out, leaving behind a chamber full of drifting light that had, for the first time in longer than it could measure, something genuinely new to remember.

EPILOGUE

HOME,

CHANGED

New Atlas — Four
Months Later

The Halcyon cleared re-entry on a gray, ordinary Tuesday afternoon, and Aiden Kade came home to find that the world he'd left had kept moving without him in all the small, stubborn ways worlds do — new construction on the harbor front, a mild scandal in the city council he'd missed entirely, Maya's hair with a few more threads of gray than the ones he'd left with her. The weapon Webb had launched had reached the Cradle's outer surface eleven minutes after the Halcyon cleared the impact radius, and had done, as far as any of them could tell from the sensor readings taken in the final desperate seconds of departure, remarkably little — a scorch mark against something the size of a moon, absorbed and forgotten the way an ocean forgets a single stone. The Loom had told the truth about that, at least.

Aiden found himself, in the long weeks of transit home, grateful for it in a way that felt strange to name.

The Council Chamber, New Atlas — One Week After Return

Director Marcus Webb did not wait to be formally investigated. He requested, the same day the Council confirmed the Halcyon's telemetry showing exactly what he had launched and when, a full public hearing — the first time in the Continuity Council's six-year history that anyone had voluntarily asked for the glass building's harshest possible light to be turned fully on themselves.

"I built a weapon and aimed it at the single most significant discovery in human history, before that discovery had even finished introducing itself," he said, standing at the same podium where Aiden had once told a retired dockworker what the truth had cost him. The gallery was full — fuller than any Tuesday session had ever drawn, word of the hearing having spread through the city in the days since the Halcyon's return. "I told myself it was contingency planning. I have had four months to sit with that explanation, and I no longer find it holds together the way it did the night I authorized it."

"Why now?" a voice from the gallery asked. "Why the hearing, instead of the resignation you could have quietly filed?"

"Because Dr. Kade built this institution on the principle that the truth, told in public, costs less in the end than the truth buried and found later," Webb said. "I spent six years quietly doubting that principle was strong enough to survive contact with something genuinely dangerous. I was wrong. It survived. I would like the record to show that I was wrong, in my own words, in the same room I doubted it in."

A young man near the back — one of the flight students who'd attended the pre-launch session months earlier — stood to ask the question that had clearly been on more minds than his own. "Do you regret it? Not the resignation. The launch itself. If you had it to do again, knowing what you know now."

Webb was quiet for a long moment, longer than any pause he'd allowed himself so far. "I regret that I didn't trust the room enough to ask first," he said finally. "I keep turning that over, more than the launch itself. I could have brought the contingency to the full Council, argued for it openly, let all of you tell me I was wrong before it ever became something irreversible. I didn't, because some part of me already suspected you'd say no, and I decided in advance that my judgment mattered more than that no would have. That's the actual failure. Not the fear. The certainty that my fear was worth more than everyone else's consent."

It was, Aiden thought, listening from the Council bench,

the closest thing to a genuinely useful answer he'd heard in six years of watching people try to explain Voss's mistake without actually naming the mechanism underneath it. Fear was not the enemy. Skipping the room was.

Aiden watched from the Council's own bench, and found, to his mild surprise, that he felt no satisfaction in the moment at all — only the tired, complicated sympathy of a man who recognized, in Webb's careful public accounting, an echo of his own worst six-year-old fear: that transparency was a comfortable philosophy for a Council that had never yet been tested by something large enough to actually threaten it.

"He wasn't wrong that something needed protecting," Aiden told Maya afterward, the two of them walking the harbor front the evening after the hearing, the city lights coming up gold against an early dusk. "He was just certain, in that specific way certainty always is, that he was the only one who could be trusted to do it."

"You could have been just as certain," Maya said. "Out there. Nobody would have blamed you for taking the safe door."

"I thought about it. For about four hours, if I'm honest." Aiden watched the water, the way he still sometimes watched it from the Spire's fourteenth floor, though the watching felt different now, lighter somehow, without a dream waiting for him underneath it.

"But safe and hollow isn't actually safe, Maya. It just delays the day you notice what you traded for it. I've delayed noticing things before. I didn't want to do it again with an entire planet's worth of choices." They walked in silence for a while, the particular comfortable silence of two people who had, between them, spent six years learning exactly how much weight the other could carry. "Do you miss her?" Maya asked finally, quietly. "The connection to her, I mean. Not just the memory." "Every day," Aiden admitted. "I think I will for the rest of my life. But she got to choose how it ended this time, and so did I, and there's a version of grief that comes with that which I didn't have six years ago. It's still grief. It's just — mine, this time. Not something that happened to me. Something I chose, with my eyes open, for a reason I still believe in."

The Continuity Council Spire, Ninth Floor — Six Months After Return

Kalinda Osei stayed on with the Council's expanding deep-range division, promoted, at twenty-six, to lead a project neither she nor anyone else had a proper name for yet: the slow, careful work of building Earth's first voluntary contribution to whatever the Loom had become — not a surrender, not a leash, but a record, chosen and curated by the people it belonged to, of exactly how one small world had faced its oldest fear and found a fourth answer nobody had thought to offer before. "It's strange work," she told Aiden, the two of them reviewing the project's early drafts in an office on the Spire's ninth floor, boxes of declassified files stacked between them in the particular chaos of a project still finding its shape.

"Deciding what a whole planet wants remembered. I keep catching myself wanting to leave out the parts that make us look bad. The containment years. My own street, half resettled because nobody built a stop switch in time. And then I remember what happens to a world that only remembers its best version of itself, and I put it back in."

"That's the job," Aiden said.
"Nobody ever really finishes deciding that. You just keep choosing, a little at a time, and hope the sum of it ends up meaning something more than the sum of your embarrassments."

"Is that what you tell yourself, writing the parts about Voss?"

"Every single day," Aiden admitted, and they both laughed, quiet and a little rueful, the specific laugh of two people who had learned, the hard way, that honesty was rarely as clean as the word made it sound.

Kalinda hesitated, then asked the question Aiden could tell she'd been carrying since the Cradle. "Do you regret it? Losing her, to get the door built?"

"I regret that it cost anything at all," Aiden said. "I don't regret which door I chose. Those aren't the same feeling, even though people mix them up all the time." He looked at the boxes of files between them, six years and one impossible voyage's worth of a species trying, imperfectly, to tell the truth about itself.

"Ask me again in twenty years. I suspect the answer gets more complicated, not less. That's usually how the true ones go."

Noah's Workshop, Lower New Atlas — Eight Months After Return

Sofia found Noah in his workshop on a quiet evening, surrounded by the scattered components of something he wouldn't yet explain, and settled onto the stool across from his workbench the way she had a hundred times in the two years since he'd finally stopped running.

"You've been quiet since Aiden got back," she said. "Quieter than your usual quiet."

Noah didn't look up from the delicate work in front of him for a long moment. "I keep thinking about the compass," he said finally. "The one I gave him before launch. He brought it back. Didn't need it, in the end — the Loom never lied to any of their instruments, not once. But he kept it in his pocket the whole time anyway, just in case the old wisdom turned out to matter more than the new sensors."

"Did it?"

"No," Noah said. "But I think carrying it mattered anyway. I think that's most of what I actually build, if I'm honest with myself. Not tools that get used.

Tools that remind someone, in a bad enough moment, that they're allowed to trust something slower and older than whatever's currently trying to convince them it's the only answer." He finally looked up. "I'm building a second one. For Kalinda. She's about to spend the next decade of her life deciding what an entire species wants remembered. I think she should have something in her pocket that isn't asking her to hurry."

Sofia smiled, the specific soft smile she rarely let anyone but Noah see. "You're a good man, Noah Petrov."

"I had a good teacher," he said, "in exactly what happens when someone isn't."

The Continuity Council Spire, Fourteenth Floor Observatory — Eleven Months After Return

It was Sofia who found the second transmission, eleven months after the Halcyon's return, buried in the same deep-space array that had once carried nothing but silence and then, for one Tuesday, everything.

It was not from the Loom. The signature was entirely new — a pattern none of the Council's systems had ever cataloged, structured, deliberate, and, unmistakably, hesitant, the way a first knock on an unfamiliar door is always slightly softer than the ones that follow.

Sofia brought it to Aiden at the same fourteenth-floor window where this had all started, the harbor turning its familiar orange beneath them, and played the message without a word.

It was faint, and it was brief, and it carried, underneath a layer of static that took the Council's best analysts three full days to fully clear, seven words in a language their systems had never before needed to translate, arriving, according to every measurement they could take, from a small yellow star system considerably farther away than any signal Earth had ever received.

We heard what you chose. We have questions.

Aiden looked out at the harbor for a long moment, the city he'd spent six years learning to trust glowing gold and ordinary beneath him, and felt something settle into place that he hadn't fully expected to feel again — not fear, and not quite hope, but the particular, clear-eyed readiness of a man who had finally stopped waiting for the story to be over.

"Get the team together," he said. "It looks like we're not the only ones the Loom left a door open for."

Somewhere far beyond the edge of anywhere Earth had ever sent a probe, a thirteenth world's answer had already begun, quietly, to ripple outward

and for the first time since a message arrived in his own handwriting sixty years too early, Aiden Kade found that he was genuinely curious to see what came next, instead of merely afraid of it.

**THE QUANTUM
ARCHIVES •
VOLUME TWO
END**

TIMELINE OF EVENTS

Twelve prior cycles — Unknown dates, unknown worlds

Twelve civilizations, each unrelated to Earth, independently develop reality-rewriting technology and reach the same crossroads. None of the twelve resolve it cleanly. The Loom forms from what's left of each.

2042 — New Atlas

Aiden Kade and Noah Petrov build the first working prototype of what will become Echo Protocol, intending to prevent a single catastrophe.

2048 — New Atlas (Echo Protocol)

Aiden discovers six years of his own memory were erased by Director Elias Voss to conceal Echo Protocol's existence. Over roughly two weeks, he uncovers the truth, is warned by a message from his own future self sent from 2078, and performs the Merge — fusing every fractured timeline into one, at the cost of his memory of raising his daughter, Aris.

2049 — New Atlas

One year after the Merge. The Global Quantum Authority is dissolved and reorganized as the Continuity Council. A new signal arrives from 2108, deep space, warning that "the cycle has started again."

2054 — New Atlas

Six years after the Merge. The Continuity Council receives a second transmission — the same warning, now carrying coordinates to an ancient structure called the Cradle. Aiden leads a mission to investigate.

2054 — The Cradle

The crew makes contact with the Loom, learns the true scale of the twelve prior cycles, survives an attempted weapon strike ordered by Director Marcus Webb, and Aiden proposes a third option — a sovereign pact — that no world has offered the Loom before. He loses his resonance link to Aris permanently as its price.

2055 — New Atlas

Eleven months after the Halcyon's return. Director Webb resigns following a public hearing. Kalinda Osei begins Earth's voluntary contribution to the Loom's archive. A new, unrelated signal arrives from a distant star system: "We heard what you chose. We have questions."

2078 — Unconfirmed

The date attached to the first future-signal received in 2049. Not yet dramatized.

2108 — Unconfirmed

The date attached to the original warning signal received at the very end of Echo Protocol. Not yet dramatized.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This book exists because readers of **Echo Protocol** kept asking what happened after the last page, and wouldn't let me pretend I didn't wonder the same thing.

Thank you to everyone who sat with Aiden, Maya, Sofia, and Noah through the first book and were willing to trust them again through a stranger, farther one. Thank you to everyone who ever had to make a hard choice alone and came out the other side willing to talk about what it cost.

And thank you, always, to the people who taught me that a story is only as strong as how clearly you can see the room it's happening in — this book is for you as much as it is for anyone.

— **Burhanuddin Munshi**

CONNECT WITH THE AUTHOR

Thank you for reading The Loom.

If you'd like to see what's next
for The Quantum Archives, or
explore
more of the author's work —

Website:

burhanuddinmunshi.vercel.app

Reviews help small, independent
projects like this one reach new
readers more than almost
anything else. If this book was
worth your
time, a few honest words
wherever you found it would
mean a great
deal.

AFTERWORD

The story you've just read is about many things.

It's about inheritance — what gets passed down, quietly, across more distance and more time than anyone volunteered for. It's about the difference between being saved and being managed, and how much that difference can cost. It's about trust, and the particular, unfamiliar loneliness of being trusted by something far older and far larger than yourself.

But more than anything, The Loom is about the second question.

Echo Protocol asked whether one person could be trusted to choose for everyone else. Aiden answered that question the only way he could — imperfectly, at real cost, and alone in the moment that mattered most. This book asks the question that only exists once the first one is already answered: what do you do when the warning that saved you comes from a version of yourself you can no longer fully trust? Aiden didn't get to answer that one alone. He got a crew, a Council, and a girl who was no longer only his daughter, standing beside him instead.

I found myself thinking, writing this book, about the twelve worlds the Loom carries inside it

not as a plot device, but as a genuine question about what a civilization owes the ones that came before it, and the ones that will come after. Every one of those twelve worlds tried to answer the same crossroads with only two doors in front of them. Aiden's real accomplishment in this book isn't defeating anything. It's noticing there was a third door nobody had thought to build yet, and building it anyway, at the cost of something he couldn't get back.

We are not owed a safety net. We are not owed a clean answer, either. What we're owed, I think, is the chance to choose — openly, together, and honestly about what it costs — instead of having the choosing done for us, no matter how kindly the hand doing it.

This book ends the way the last one did: with an invitation instead of a resolution. Somewhere out past the edge of anything Earth has ever touched, another world heard what Aiden chose, and wants to know how he did it. I hope that's the part that stays with you longest — not the amber light, not the twelve worlds, but the plain, stubborn fact that somebody, somewhere, is always still asking the question properly, for the first time, on purpose.

— **Burhanuddin Munshi**

THE QUANTUM ARCHIVES CONTINUE

**"WE HEARD WHAT YOU
CHOSE. WE HAVE
QUESTIONS."**

**AIDEN'S CHOICE MAY
HAVE
ANSWERED THE LOOM BUT
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**THE QUANTUM ARCHIVES:
VOLUME III — COMING
SOON**

THE QUANTUM ARCHIVES • VOLUME TWO

*"THE CYCLE HAS STARTED AGAIN.
PREPARE."*

*"A TWISTING, HIGH-CONCEPT THRILLER
ABOUT INHERITANCE, TRUST, AND THE
COST OF DOUBTING THE ONE PERSON
WHO'S ALREADY LIVED THROUGH YOUR
MISTAKE."*

SCIENCE FICTION – THRILLER